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Interreligious Hermeneutics, Prejudice, and the Problem of Testimonial Injustice

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ABSTRACT

As interreligious educators we challenge our students to engage in hermeneutical self-reflection. In this article, I turn the tables, and engage in an exercise of reflective practice: I look back on my own pedagogy, consider my own religiously diverse classroom, and ask in what way the theoretical framework from which I approach interreligious learning has facilitated *and* hindered the learning process of my students. I especially inquire into chances and limits of the hermeneutical approach of interreligious learning, an approach with which I identify. I will first elaborate on the importance of the so-called hermeneutical approach to interreligious learning and dwell on my own appropriation of this approach. Here the French philosopher Paul Ricoeur and his hermeneutical anthropology will occupy center stage. Next, and triggered by my own experiences as an interfaith educator, I will argue that the hermeneutical approach to interreligious learning has a tendency to level relations between self and other and falls short when it comes to reckoning with unequal power relations. I will illustrate this shortcoming on the basis of a concrete case of testimonial injustice that has occurred in my classroom.

Introduction: Hermeneutical entanglements

In the pedagogy of religion there is a strong line of theory development that applies the insights of philosophical hermeneutics to interreligious learning (Jackson 1997; Jette 2018; Pollefeyt 2007). Here, interreligious learning is less about a transfer of knowledge about religions than about promoting understanding between self and other. Under this approach, one of the most important interreligious competencies is that of hermeneutical self-reflection (i.e., critical consideration of the way one's own profound assumptions and convictions affect how one experiences, understands, and relates to those of other faiths). Being embodied and embedded, *all* human persons are unavoidably prejudiced; the challenge is not to let those prejudices get the upper hand. Unexamined prejudices have to be surfaced and students need to learn to understand how their assumptions may lead them to misconstrue the other and her/his tradition(s). As is well known, often it is only in the encounter with a significant other that we become aware of our own blind spots and we may begin the process of revisiting our own assumptions.

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Teachers are also part of this hermeneutical process. Based on our experience, expertise, and pedagogical vision we guide, direct, and orient and hence profoundly impact the learning process of our students. Inevitably our own framework of reference shapes our classroom. That framework is not only composed of personal experiences, assumptions, and deep convictions, it is also influenced by dominant theoretical discussions about interreligious learning. As we develop our teaching strategies, we tap into and are inspired by the theoretical work of education scholars and, at the same time, we critically examine what works and does not work in our classrooms.

As interreligious educators we challenge our students to engage in hermeneutical self-reflection, to surface hidden assumptions and uncover blind spots. In this article, I turn the tables, and engage as an interreligious educator in an exercise of reflective practice. I look back on my own interfaith pedagogy, consider my own religiously diverse classroom, and examine how the theoretical framework that undergirds my teaching has both facilitated *and* hindered the learning process of my students. I especially inquire into opportunities and limits of the aforementioned hermeneutical approach of interreligious learning, an approach with which I identify. I will first elaborate on the importance of the so-called hermeneutical approach to interreligious learning and dwell on my own appropriation of this approach. Here the French philosopher Paul Ricoeur and his hermeneutical anthropology will occupy center stage (Moyaert 2014; Ricoeur 1995a). Next, and triggered by my own experiences as an interfaith educator, I will argue that the hermeneutical approach to interreligious learning has a tendency to level relations between self and other and falls short when it comes to acknowledging unequal power relations. I will illustrate this shortcoming on the basis of a concrete case of testimonial injustice that has occurred in my classroom.

The context from which I speak

Since the end of the 20th century and especially the beginning of the 21st, international, national, and local political policymakers have expressed their concern about the problem of growing intolerance (i.e., misunderstandings, negative stereotypes, and provocative images that are being used to depict those who practice and believe differently) (Gearon 2010, 861–63). If the preservation of the right to freedom of religion was seen as a primary task of politics until recently, the question now of interest is how to develop an active diversity policy to tackle the problem of growing intolerance and discrimination (Bramadat and Koenig 2009). Most policymakers agree that education, especially, plays an enormous role in combating religious prejudice, promoting mutual understanding, and fostering social cohesion (Roebben 2016). The questions are, *How shall we teach for a multifaith world? How shall we educate people so that they are able not only to speak about religious diversity in nuanced way but also ready to build bridges across communities? How do we form people so that they are better equipped to show leadership in a word of religious diversity?*

In response to this societal need, both in Europe as in the United States, higher educational programs focused on training interreligious leaders are surfacing at a rapid pace (Foody 2016, 719). I myself work at the Faculty of Religion and Theology at the Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam, where I coordinate a small master's program called

Building Interreligious Relations (ten students each year), which forms interreligious scholar activists. Furthermore, I teach a compulsory course on Hermeneutics to all master's-level students (Christian, Buddhist, Hindu, Muslim, spiritual but not religous, multiple Religious belongers, and atheists) in the Religion and Theology department (Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam), the goal of which is to enhance the students' interreligious literacy. I understand interreligious literacy as the skill to sensitively and effectively relate to people who believe and practice differently. In my understanding, interfaith literacy supposes (1) humility (i.e., an attentiveness to the limits of one's own knowledge); (2) self-reflexivity (i.e., an attentiveness to not only the limits of one's own knowledge but to its prejudiced nature as well); (3) curiosity (i.e., the motivation to learn more); and (4) an open-mindedness (i.e., an attentiveness to the nuanced and complex perspectives of people who belong to different traditions). As an educator, I try to foster interpersonal spaces that facilitate the cultivation of these "virtues."

Unlike what is likely to be the case in many other interfaith programs, my students are not all committed to the cause of interreligious learning, and they certainly do not all agree with the discourse that religious diversity is a blessing. While some students explicitly come to study religion and theology at the Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam precisely because of its multicultural and multireligious character and its dedication to dialog, some sign up for one of its tradition-specific trajectories, such as Islamic theology, Baptist theology, or Buddhist Spiritual Care. Still others are more research oriented or seeking to become religious media experts. When it comes to their attitude toward interreligious learning, we have a mixed bag. More than a few of my students are highly skeptical of the whole enterprise of dialog, which they negatively associate with a modern discourse about liberal pluralism and the watering down of their religious identities, and, on top of that, many have had few dealings with people of other faiths. Conversely, some of them ask if believers who embrace so-called exclusivist theologies of religions are capable of engaging in a meaningful dialog across traditions. Still others argue that interreligiosity is a societal phenomenon that requires close scholarly attention, but they do not see how it has anything to do with them—given that, as religious scholars, they are observers, not participants. To their mind, their own religious identity is irrelevant to their learning path. As religious scholars they claim a posture of neutrality.

If at least part of my pedagogical goal is to build bridges to people who believe and practice differently, the first question I struggled with is how to engage all of my students in the process of interreligious learning. How do I communicate that learning across traditions is something that concerns both pluralists and exclusivists, believers and nonbelievers, theologians and religious scholars, Muslims, Christians, Buddhists and Hindus alike, and that acquiring dialogical competencies is something from which they will all benefit? What I wanted to avoid at all costs was to give the impression that interfaith learning is something that concerns religious people exclusively (thus, not my atheist students or those who claim to be without any tradition) or that it is only of concern from a liberal-Christian perspective (that excludes my exclusivist students).

Ricoeur and the hermeneutics of interreligious learning

I judged that it was not conducive to frame my classes around the by now well-known threefold paradigm of exclusivism, inclusivism, and pluralism (Race 1983). First of all, it

would force my "non-Christian students" into a mold that does not fit them—after all, theology of religions and its soteriological question is an intra-Christian debate (Fredericks 2010, xv). Furthermore, this discussion would exclude all non-theologians from the conversation, and, last but not least, I worried that the theology of religious pluralism approach would end up pitting so-called exclusivists, inclusivists, and pluralists against each other and involve them in an endless discussion about which model succeeds best in finding a balance between openness and identity. Moreover, this paradigm often works to the advantage of the pluralists who present themselves as the guardians of dialogical openness, putting both (closed) exclusivists and (half-open) inclusivists on the defensive (Moyaert 2011, chap. 2).

Moving beyond the theologies of the religious pluralism paradigm, I made the pedagogical decision to frame the challenge of religious diversity as a hermeneutical question (rather than a theological one): Given that there are so many misunderstandings between people who believe and practice differently, how can we promote and improve mutual understanding among those who believe and practice differently? To my mind, the French philosopher Paul Ricoeur is a rewarding conversation partner to think through the challenge of interfaith learning (Garcia 2008; Kearney 2010; Matern 2008; Taylor 2011). In his magnum opus, *Oneself as Another* (1991), Ricoeur does not place self and other in an antithetical scheme, but shows how selfhood is always interconnected with and constituted by otherness. Put differently, from a Ricoeurian perspective, dialog is not something that is needed because of recent societal changes. Rather, to be human is to be dialogical. This also implies that dialog is not something that should concern some rather than others. It belongs to the very heart of what it means to be human. To live one's life as a human person is to be involved in a never-ending hermeneutical process.

Ricoeur—and I follow his lead—used to begin his classes with a key question: *d'où parlez- vous*?[1] Where do you speak from? This is a question about positionality, and it springs from the realization that the context from which one speaks impacts the way one encounters and interprets the world. In giving this question center stage, Ricoeur draws attention to what he—inspired by Heidegger and Gadamer—called the hermeneutical condition of human existence, thereby at once pushing back against the way modern Western philosophy has come to think about the 'subject' as exalted, self-sufficient, uprooted, and disembodied (Ricoeur 1992). Well-known is Ricoeur's critique of the Cartesian Cogito that, after having freed itself from prejudiced traditions handed down from one generation, projects the ideals of objectivity, detachment, and invulnerability (Lundin 1999). In Ricoeur's view, the modern subject conceals its epistemic location, thereby at once paving the way for claims of universality that on closer inspection are unwarranted and turn out to be expressions of historico-culturally determined ideas. Claims to neutrality all too often protect deeper assumptions from questions and critique.

Reacting against the modern tradition symbolized by Descartes's cogito, Ricoeur emphasized that the human person is always embodied and embedded in a whole web

[1]See for example "Dialogue avec Ricoeur sur la psychanalyse (24.1.64)," *Cahiers de philosophie – UNEF – FGEL* Vol 2 no. 8, http://www.fondsricoeur.fr/uploads/medias/articles_pr/cahiers-de-philo-dialogue-pr-sur-psychanalyse-v3.pdf (accessed July 10, 2018).

of interpersonal relations that unfold in a historico-culturally determined context in which particular traditions prevail. Long before the human person begins to self-consciously carve out her or his path in life, her or his "minded body" has already been inscribed by unchosen or, as Ricoeur would say, involuntary dimensions, like one's mother tongue, religious adherence, and cultural background. Building on his anthropology of the self as an embodied and embedded person, who always finds her- or himself in media res, Ricoeur emphasizes that world we live in is never an object in front of us, but we are already part of it in a particular way, and we engage it from a specific perspective with all sorts of (good and bad) assumptions. It basically belongs to the human constitution to be prejudiced. That is, all of us operate out of certain biases that come from being a "situated" and historical human being and not a human being in general. This is not necessarily a negative thing. On the contrary. whenever we try to understand something that does not belong to our familiar world, we try to make sense of it by connecting it to or framing it in what we do know. Thus, we develop a first, somewhat naïve understanding; without it, we would simply have no access at all to what is strange.

While prejudice marks our human condition, there is no need for some kind of postmodern fatalism. Contrary to the idea that human persons are predetermined by their context, Ricoeur argues that the capacity to reflect on one's choices and actions is part and parcel of being human and that the human person is capable of self-reflection. Such critical self-reflection involves developing a more profound understanding of the deeper assumptions, values, norms, beliefs that govern us as we act and interact in this world. This includes inquiring if the life we lead corresponds to the vision of the person we aspire to be and contributes to the well-being of others and the establishment of a just society. This hermeneutical process of critical self-reflection may also imply the possibility of developing new and more meaningful, authentic, and just ways of acting and interacting. Action requires reflection, and reflection leads to action (Ricoeur 1991).

For Ricoeur, and this is an idea that I would like to emphasize, self-reflection is a moral responsibility, and to not accept this responsibility may have harmful consequences. To not answer the question "Where do I speak from?" (and how does this impact the world and the way I act in it) may very well lead to the perseverance of particular blind spots, as a consequence of which morally corrupt situations remain unaddressed. To accept this responsibility is part of what it means to be ethical human (i.e., hermeneutical) beings.

Instead of chasing after the modern dream of neutrality, Ricoeur starts by arguing that we are all prejudiced or biased and that all claims to neutrality or objectivity are not only overstated, but should be met with suspicion. Pushing back against some kind of postmodern fatalism, however, he emphasized human responsibility and the capacity of self-reflection (in that sense, Ricoeur proves himself to be an heir of reflexive philosophy). In brief, being prejudiced as such is not problematic. What is problematic, however, is (1) its denial, which thereafter leads into (2) a rejection of criticism.

Typical of Ricoeur's philosophy, he connects this hermeneutical responsibility of critical self-reflection not only with the promise of receiving a better and transformed self-understanding, but also with that of becoming a better person. He means that we always come to self-understanding—better insight into who we are as persons, what drives and

inspires us, what frightens us, what attracts us—by engaging others. Those others may be "real others," people we encounter on the journey of our life and with whom we find ourselves in conversation, but, to Ricoeur's mind, these others may also take the form of works of art, poetry and literature, and, as he would sometimes add, the great texts of the world religions too may function as significant others (Ricoeur 1995b; Ricoeur and LaCocque 1998). This conversation with significant others not only enables us to recognize the particularity of our own epistemic location as the result of a combination of chosen and unchosen dimensions, the acknowledgment of the embedded and embodied context from which we speak, confronting and exploring various interpretations in conversation may also help us acknowledge the limits of what we know and experience to be valuable and true. Such insight opens up the way for mutual transformation and enrichment in the learning process.

Approaching the encounter between those who believe and practice differently from the perspective of hermeneutical anthropology has enabled me to engage all students regardless of what they believe or do not believe, regardless of whether they are exclusivists or pluralists, Hindus or Muslims, and so on. They all speak from somewhere, and all of them need to do the work of critical self-reflection as they engage people who believe and practice differently and as they try to make sense of texts, practices, symbols, and events that are part of foreign traditions. I found the way Ricoeur's hermeneutical anthropology created some sort of "equal" starting position for all of my students especially appealing: they all start from somewhere and when confronted with difference they face similar challenges. What is more, turning to hermeneutics, I can communicate to those students who claim a position of neutrality that there is no such thing, to my liberal or pluralist students that they also have to do the work of self-criticism (what are the blind spots of their position), and to my exclusivists that there is no reason of principle why they would not be able to enter into a meaningful dialog with others, but that they cannot use confessional arguments to refuse self-criticism or to fall back in a position of hermeneutical closure. Last not but least, Ricoeur's hermeneutical anthropology also creates a certain reciprocity among the students, since we need each other to come to a better understanding of self and other.

While Ricoeur has been a tremendously helpful conversation partner, several years of teaching and specific interactions in my classroom have made me conscious of the need to complement his hermeneutical anthropology and interreligious hermeneutics with insights from critical epistemology. Based on my experiences as an interfaith educator, I have come to conclude that Ricoeur, while helpful in many ways, does not sufficiently reckon with the issue of power and how it may affect the encounter between self and other. Ricoeur's hermeneutical anthropology according to which we are all others and according to which we are all prejudiced, downplays the reality that some people are more "different" than others, because they deviate from the norm of the majority. The meeting between self and other is not always one between equals, but rather one marked by unequal power relations between those belonging to majority/minority groups.

The problem of hermeneutical and testimonial injustice

As I explained above, Ricoeur's hermeneutical anthropology is appealing because he enables me to present the challenge of (interreligious) dialog as a matter that

concerns all of us as embedded and embodied beings. We always start *in medias res*, and there is no escape from the hermeneutical circle (Placher 1987, 39). This reality confronts all of us with the ethical and hermeneutical responsibility to engage in critical self-reflection. Prejudice as such is not the problem but rather our failing to see and critically relate to the assumptions that direct and misdirect the way we think and act. That is why we need dialog with people who believe and practice differently. In our going back and forth, we may realize the limits of our own perspective, welcome the possibility to learn from others and become aware of the complexity of the world in which we live. Ricoeur's starting point is that of equality: we all face similar challenges when meeting others, whether these others are historical, cultural, or religious others.

The problem with this "equalizing" tendency of Ricoeur's hermeneutical anthropology—as he would say: we all live after Babel (Ricoeur 2006)—is that it covers up the power relations in the classroom (and society at large) and that (1) while we all may be prejudiced, some are more prejudiced than others, and that (2) some suffer more from certain prejudices than others. In short, being prejudiced may affect all of us but not all of us equally, and some prejudices are more harmful than others.

It has been my educational experience that what some students bring to the conversation is simply not taken seriously—not because they do not have anything significant to say or because their contribution would be of no value but because what they say does not fit the dominant (often implicit) hermeneutical framework of the majority. On the other hand, I have also observed how some students resist critical self-reflection and simply remain deaf to counterevidence and "continue to misunderstand and misinterpret the world" (Pohlhaus 2012, 716). Rather than developing the virtues of humility, curiosity, and openmindedness, their hermeneutical attitude seems to amount to closed-mindedness.

From this follows my claim that when we do not address the power imbalances in the classroom, this interfaith space that aims at equal inclusion becomes one of unequal exclusion. I now will further unpack the problem of inequality in the classroom by zooming in on two related types of "epistemic injustice," namely that of testimonial injustice and hermeneutical marginalization.

Testimonial injustice

A case written based on my classroom experience serves as my starting point.

> Norah is a young feminist practicing Muslim with an immigrant background, who wears a hijab. During a class on clothing and modesty two liberal protestants comment on the way she dresses. They argue that her dress code is clearly expressive of her submission to religious rules that serve the interests of men and functions as a token of the oppressive nature of Islam. To their mind, the hijab represents the patriarchal oppression of a backward tradition. Norah objects to this picture and tries to explain why she dresses this way and in her answer she clearly claims agency and deconstructs the liberal opposition between autonomy and heteronomy. She says that she was not forced nor obliged to wear the hijab, nobody made this decision for her, she was free to make up her own mind. For a long time, she did not wear a hijab, however at the age of 15 she decided to start wearing it for several reasons. However, it is as if her colleagues do not hear what she says and they continue by asking (in a suggestive way) if she has to wear the hijab from her father or

> brothers? She denies, and tries again. She talks about "modesty" and being focused on a prayerful life. It gives her spiritual peace. One student asks: "Does that mean you think religion needs such material externalities to express a deep spiritual life. Do you really think *your God* cares about such things?" Another comes back to the question of oppression and asks her if she thinks woman's sexuality is a distraction for men and is that why she needs covering? She denies both of these interpretations, and reacts by pointing at the sexualization of young women in the Netherlands. That is an unfortunate choice on her part; my liberal protestant students now reproach her for wanting to turn back the clock on the sexual revolution. … Norah no longer answers. In the next sessions she is quiet.

First of all, this case provides insight into what Miranda Fricker calls testimonial injustice in her (2007) book *Epistemic Injustice: Power and the Ethics of Knowing*. For Fricker, testimony should be taken as a rather broad category including not only all cases of telling/narrating but also formulating a hypothesis, launching an idea, building an argument, and so on. According to her definition, testimonial injustice "happens whenever prejudice on the part of a hearer causes them to attribute a deflated level of credibility to a speaker's word" (Fricker 2007, 1). Testimonial injustice is about not accrediting the appropriate credibility to someone's testimonial activity, not because the speaker has nothing meaningful to say or contribute to the conversation but because she is simply not recognized as a credible source of knowledge. What she says falls on deaf ears or is dismissed as irrelevant, worthless or as making no sense at all. Such testimonial injustice may be inflicted on a speaker by an individual or a collective body (like a court of law). Typical of situations of testimonial injustice are those in which the hearer resists whatever counterevidence the speaker offers. Testimonial injustice, which harms a person in her capacity as knower, usually takes root in pervasive negative prejudice. When prejudice gets a hold of a hearer, it affects his judgment of a speaker, leading him to unduly deflate the speaker's level of credibility. The worst expression of negative prejudice is what Fricker calls a negative collective identity-prejudicial stereotype. She understands this as "a widely held disparaging association between a social group and one or more attributes, where this association embodies a generalization that displays some (typically, epistemically culpable) resistance to counterevidence owing to an ethically bad affective investment" (Fricker 2007, 35).

The above case shows how some students in the classroom simply do not grant credibility to Norah's experiential testimonial. Her voice is disregarded, and the knowledge she produces is neglected. In the end, her response is to render herself invisible and to become silent. Her case makes clear that she was tired of trying to argue uphill. I am also inclined to say that Norah is the victim of a negative identity-prejudicial stereotype (Fricker 2007) that distorts her colleagues' perception of what she says and leads them to silence her. It is assumed that she herself does not know best what she experiences and believes. I think that Norah is a victim of profound negative stereotypes about Islam, which are deeply ingrained in the sociocultural and political imaginary of the Netherlands, the country where I work and teach.

For a long time, the Netherlands presented itself as an open and tolerant society, welcoming to cultural and religious others. This has changed (SPIOR 2013). Especially since September 11, 2001 (9/11) and the murders of Van Gogh and Pim Fortuyn,[2]

[2]Significantly, Pim Fortuyn was not murdered by a Muslim, but by Volkert van der Graaf, a Dutch environmentalist activist.

negative rhetoric about Islam has become more widespread. The discussion about migration and integration gained momentum and the tone of the sociopolitical debate became harder. Muslims are increasingly being framed as Others in the media and public debates (Morey and Yaqin 2011). "Islam" is under siege: it is viewed as a violent and backward religion. Muslim men are seen as potential extremists, and Muslim women are often viewed as the embodiment of gender oppression (Brems 2014; Moors 2009). Islam's material and ritual practices especially have become associated with the oppression of women, premodern irrationality, and violence (Westerduin, Jansen, and Neutel 2014). These negative stereotypes go hand in hand with a strong resistance to counterevidence.

In my reading, different aspects of Nora's identity interlock and diminish her credibility: First of all, there is the fact that she practices Islam and attaches importance to visible signs of faith. If we read the case carefully, we cannot but notice how the liberal Protestant students associate Islam with patriarchy, the oppression of women, and overvaluation of the external (visible, material, ritual) dimension of religion. A practicing Muslim woman, Norah is perceived as a product of a patriarchal and oppressive religion that is associated with premodernity and irrationality. "Her veil [has become] a bodily mark that signals her being a Muslim and thus a 'subordinate Other potentially oppressed by her religion. This is because wearing a veil is not always perceived as a sign of free choice. … Due to wearing of the veil she is not seen to belong to the group of autonomous, reasonable wise, and rational adults anymore (the same)" (Riitaoja and Dervin 2014, 79). As a consequence, she is not regarded as a credible source of knowledge by her fellow students. I presume, though, since the case does not provide the evidence to corroborate this, that Norah's credibility status is further lowered by the fact that she is a young woman (when it comes to religion, men rather than women are seen as authorities) with a migrant background. She is denied the intellectual respect that she deserves; rather, her "body" is seen as in need of liberation and of course emancipation. This is particularly harmful because the classroom now functions as a place where the prejudices that are widespread in society at large are reiterated.

Hermeneutical injustice

The situation of testimonial injustice described above is inextricably related with another phenomenon, namely that of hermeneutical injustice. According to Fricker, hermeneutical injustice is defined as "the injustice of having some significant area of one's social experience obscured from collective understanding owing to hermeneutical marginalization" (2007, 35). When talking about hermeneutical injustice, there are two possibilities. On the one hand, the available and widely shared concepts and interpretations that are part of the sociocultural imaginary do not enable an individual or social group to make sense of a particularly significant experience they themselves are experiencing. Miranda Fricker gives the example of women trying to render intelligible their deep experiences of distress before knowing that a condition like a post-partum depression actually existed and before it had become a widely shared concept. On the other hand, it is possible that an individual or social group has developed the language, concepts,

ideas, and images to make sense of a particularly significant experience and that they are able to communicate it to others, but not to significant others to whom they wish to communicate and whom they perhaps want to influence.

Hermeneutical injustice, according to Fricker, occurs especially when an individual/social group has an unequal opportunity to contribute to what pertains to the widely shared concepts of the sociopolitical imaginary, thereby at once constituting her/them as a less than full partner in the social interaction. There is a mismatch between their experiences (and the concepts they use to make sense of these experiences) and the available concepts and ideas that belong to the sociopolitical imaginary and this conceptual mismatch or hermeneutical gap, as it is sometimes also called, hinders communication and limits mutual understanding and transformation.

While hermeneutical and testimonial injustice are two distinct forms of epistemic injustice, both are interrelated and reinforce each other. On the one hand, hermeneutical injustice is perpetuated by negative identity prejudices, which lead hearers to negatively judge the credibility of any speaker trying to communicate a significant social experience that does not fit in with the widely shared concepts of the powerful social group in society. To put it simply, if one does not understand someone or finds that she is simply not making sense but ascribes her a high amount of credibility, one will by all likelihood push through and listen carefully and generously, until one reaches understanding. No such attempt will be made if a negative judgment of the credibility status of the speaker is in place. On the other hand, Fricker has a point when she declares that hermeneutical injustice usually precedes testimonial injustice: "Lacking the conceptual and interpretive tools you need to [render intelligible] some significant patch of your social experience is prior to the difficulties of getting your word received without prejudice once you have put your thoughts together in intelligible form" (qtd. in Dieleman 2012, 258).

Let me return once more to the case. I have already explained how Norah suffers from testimonial injustice and her testimony is not taken seriously because she is a Muslim with a migrant background. She also suffers from hermeneutical injustice: she fails to communicate how being a feminist, practicing Muslim "works for her" and is not a contradiction in terms. What she says makes no sense to her fellow students. To my mind, the reason for this is because her particular way of life does not resonate with and actually seems to contradict some of the widely shared ideas about what I have elsewhere called "good" religion (i.e., religion that is de-politicized, interiorized, individualized, and ethicized). Good religion, which resembles liberal Protestantism remarkably, springs from individual choice, is emancipated and rational. This is religion that has gone through the critique of modernity and the Enlightenment and "knows and accepts" its proper place in society: it shows itself to be a reliable ally of policy-makers when it comes to keeping the social peace and advocating for human rights, but when not called on it operates discretely. Good religion is pious and turned inward—it has no need of visible signs to "prove" itself. Bad religion, on the other hand, is materialized and is turned outward (Meyer and Houtman 2012). It is visible and palpable, as if it wants to show off. Bad religion, moreover, values the community over the individual, the law over freedom, rituals over ethics. I take these binaries to be part and parcel

of the sociocultural imaginary of the Netherlands, and I assume these binaries contribute to the hermeneutical injustice experienced by Norah.[3]

Especially since 9/11, Islam has been constructed as a backward premodern religion that is forced on adherents through family (the patriarchal tradition). This understanding of Islam clashes with the understanding of good, modern, liberal religion, which is the result of self-determination. It is collectivist rather than individualistic, legalistic rather than spiritual, premodern rather than modern. The prevailing discourse on Islam as a potentially dangerous religion is that it must become enlightened, "just like Christianity" was forced to adapt to modernity. In Norah's case, her liberal Protestant fellow students claim a higher Enlightenment status than Islam. Norah fails to communicate how being a Muslim wearing a veil (visibility) and following Islamic ritual practice can go hand in hand with being emancipated, and that following tradition does not contradict making choices. This failure has to do with the fact that her way of life is at odds with what is being taken for granted by some belonging to the majority culture, which is fixated on thinking in binaries. She challenges the liberal understanding of religion and religious agency, according to which Muslim women are in need of liberation and emancipation (Mahmood 2005). The idea that practicing Islam and choosing to follow its rules would be an expression of feminist agency remains inconceivable. It simply does not fit their social imaginary, and however she tries to make sense of it, does not work. Her fellow students simply do not understand her, and because they do not regard her as a credible source of knowledge—even when it comes to communicating her own experiences—they also do not make any attempt to try and understand her. In the end, those who are marginalized do not participate in defining what is meaningful in a classroom (or society at large; May 2014). Because Norah is not taken seriously, she is unable to communicate her experience and is unable to change the mindset of these students who embody the sociocultural imaginary of the majority. That one can be a feminist and a practicing Muslim seems to be beyond some of my students' imagination. They simply cannot wrap their minds around that. Rather than facilitating a transformation, Norah's lowered credibility reaffirms the status quo.

From a pedagogical perspective, this situation first of all negatively affects Norah, who is misrecognized in her capacity of producing knowledge that is worthy of consideration. Because of the dialogical nature of the human person, which implies that recognition is a human need, misrecognition (the fact that she is not recognized as a credible source of knowledge) is very painful and may adversely affect her ability to further develop her communicative skills. It is not uncommon for students who are faced with this sort of misrecognition in a systemic way to withdraw from contributing to the conversation and become silent.

Pedagogically speaking, however, testimonial injustice is also a problem for those students who cut themselves off from important insights and basically limit their own potential to learn more and understand better. They simply repeat what they already think they know. To my mind, what we are seeing here is a display not simply of an innocent lack of knowledge or limited perspective; rather, we are dealing with what has been called willful active ignorance, which sets in motion a whole set of defense

[3]For a genealogy of religion, see Orsi (2016). Masuzwaka (2005) and King (1999).

mechanisms that make individuals and collective groups insensitive to what is being communicated to them. Such willful ignorance presents itself primarily among those who belong to a privileged and dominant social group that sees no benefit in changing its mind or in questioning well-established and widely shared concepts and interpretations. The outcome is a situation where, "despite the availability of alternative conceptualizations put forth by marginalized, resistant knowers, dominantly situated knowers nonetheless continue to misunderstand and misinterpret the world" (Pohlhaus 2012, 716). The latter's prejudiced and problematic images perpetuate, their ignorance continues, and epistemic improvement is hindered when they do not acquire important insights about the pluralized world in which they live.

Conclusion

The way we, as educators, create interfaith spaces needs further consideration. Committed to the hermeneutical process of interfaith learning, we expect our students to engage in critical self-reflection and as teachers we should do the same. We should be especially conscious of how the theorists we think with leave their mark on how we consider interfaith learning and frame our education. A question we should never lose sight of is whether the space we are framing succeeds or fails at being inclusive.

The strength of the hermeneutical approach to interreligious learning is that it draws attention to the way misunderstanding and misrepresentation often flow from prejudiced preliminary interpretations and that being biased belongs to our human condition after Babel. Ricoeur makes a valid and important point when he argues that claims to neutrality or objectivity are usually overstated and spring from a denial of what it means to be a hermeneutical, embodied, and embedded being. I also appreciate the fact that the reality and even the normalcy of prejudice does not lead to a diminishing human responsibility. Prejudice may be normal, but some prejudices really do lead to bad understanding and misrepresentation and can be remedied in the interaction with significant others. Such interaction may not only lead to better understanding of the other but also to better self-understanding. Ricoeur's anthropology is neither optimist nor pessimist—he believes in the possibility of transformation, even though this is a process that is never ending.

The hermeneutical approach to interreligious learning, however, has its limits. To be more precise, I think it fails to recognize that misunderstanding is not solely an individual problem but a structural one, deeply imbedded in society's power relations. His hermeneutic lacks a recognition of how the background norms and perceptions of the dominant sociocultural imaginary shape the ground for interfaith learning in such a way that it may become very difficult for students to learn from and with each other.

When I apply Ricoeur's hermeneutics to my classroom, it would seem that we have different embodied and embedded students who bring their own background to the "table" and have to learn to navigate between those who believe and practice differently. Everyone brings his or her set of experiences, family values, religious convictions, and cultural traditions to weigh in on the interpretation of this or that scriptural passage and engages the others in an ongoing mutual process of endorsement and correction. However, Norah's case points to the reality of a power imbalance between the

majority–minority dynamic in any classroom situation—even when there are an equal number of Muslim and (liberal) Christian students present. The message Ricoeur's hermeneutics communicate, namely, that "we are all others, we are all particular, we are all prejudiced and we all struggle with and against misunderstanding" banalizes this power imbalance and does not reckon with the fact that some groups actually "have primary access … to the means of interpretation and communication in society … the dominant cultural products of the society that is, those most widely disseminated, to express the experience, values and achievements of these groups. Often without noticing they do so, the dominant groups project their own experience as representative of humanity as such. … Since only the dominant group's cultural expressions receive wide dissemination their cultural expressions become the normal … and thereby unremarkable against which differences are reconstructed largely as deviance and inferiority. Thus minority groups find themselves in the paradoxical situation of both being rendered invisible by the dominant meanings of a society, and at the same time stereotyped as a group and marked as other" (2000, 34).

While some of my students speak from a privileged majority perspective and are able to tap into the dominant sociocultural imaginary, they do not encounter a mismatch between their experiences and the hermeneutical resources widely shared in society. Norah actually starts from a less privileged position where she needs to argue uphill. She not only has to push back at her fellow students' point of view in the classroom, but she is faced with similar challenges when she leaves the classroom and moves about in society, where she suffers bias on a daily basis.

While interfaith learning is often regarded as an expression of inclusion and an appreciation of diversity, in reality, this is rather the ideal situation and, not uncommonly, happens in a space where certain deeply anchored prejudices prove to be very resistant. Interfaith space is not only a space of recognition, too often it is also a space of misunderstanding. Sometimes misunderstanding is innocent and simply the result of a lack of knowledge or even wrong knowledge. Other times, however, more is at stake, and then Ricoeurian claims about how we are all different and prejudiced will simply not suffice.

Having learned from the above classroom experience and after having examined the theoretical framework that undergirds my teaching, I have begun to change my own pedagogy. While I still draw heavily on Ricoeur's hermeneutical anthropology and I continue to appreciate the way he perceives of life as an ongoing hermeneutical journey, I have moved away from the idea of *presumed* equality (which enables students who belong to the majority to nestle comfortably). Early on in my teaching I inject an intersectional approach into my *hermeneutical interfaith pedagogy* and I have introduced a majority/minority analysis (Moyaert 2018, 156). I now draw attention to the way we tend to hierarchize the world and (unintentionally) rank the voices we take seriously, according to gender, ethnicity, and class. Furthermore, I also teach about the genealogy of religion and the normative distinction between good/bad religion. I challenge them to critically reflect on which religious beliefs and practices they associate with good or bad religion, how that association may be related to the genealogy of religion, and how it affects the way they (do not) relate to those of other faiths (Moyaert 2018, 156). I try to make them aware of the fact that interfaith encounters do not necessarily happen

between equals and that interfaith learning without a power analysis may even further divide people who believe and practice differently.

I still ask Ricoeur's question, *Where do you speak from?,* but when answering this question my students have to check their privileges and examine to what extent their positionality is interrelated with (the lack of) power and how their positionality may contribute to situations of hermeneutical and testimonial injustice, particularly in the encounter with the religious other.

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